revolutionary circles as ‘Durga Bhabhi’) in an interview she gave in 1972. She was one of the few women in the HSRA and the one who accompanied Bhagat Singh on the train when he made his itinerant escape in disguise after the shooting J.P. Saunders. So she would probably have known better than Chhabil Das, who ended up being deceived in this way.

What also made such trickery possible was that Bhagat Singh, who had an interest in Congress politics, also attended earlier Congress sessions. On the face of it, this is not altogether unusual, because back in the 1920s there was a degree of shared communion between the Congress Party and the Naujawan Sabha. Indeed, the CID itself had confirmed how it was the ‘consistent practice of revolutionaries from various parts of India to take advantage of the annual sessions of the Congress in order to discuss their plans in secret, and to interchange their views’, and as MacLean makes clear, ‘this almost certainly accounts for Bhagat Singh’s activities in Calcutta’.[11] This is how, as surviving revolutionaries have since confirmed, Bhagat Singh managed during this period to establish contacts with Bengali organizations, such as the Anushilan Samiti (Bodybuilding Society) in Calcutta. This arose from an amalgamation of local youths and bodybuilding gyms (Akhara) in 1902. Anushilan Samiti was dedicated to the use of revolutionary violence to end British rule in India. As the HSRA began to orient its focus to bomb-making, it became more attractive to other organizations devoted to the use of revolutionary violence in the cause of gaining national freedom. With its headquarters in Agra, the HSRA went on to extend its activities in the United Provinces with satellite operations elsewhere.

Bhagat Singh was known to be active in Allahabad in January 1929 because the testimony of Lalit Kumar Mukherji, who turned ‘approver’, was that he had met a sardar, by the name of ‘Ranjit’, which was another name that Bhagat Singh was known by, at a secret meeting where the assassination of CID officers was discussed between them.[12] Such was the extent to which he was by now nationally known that the intelligence bureau had confirmed that Bhagat Singh was ‘wandering about India in the most suspicious manner the past few months’, although they did not seem